

TRAILING ELEGANCE

At the turn of the 15th century fashion for the nobility became more extravagant. Improved technology allowed weavers to run riot with patterns of twining symmetrical fruit and flowers, or geometric motifs. Italians invented velvet, with its sumptuous pile. Better looms meant the aristocracy could buy more of their favourite taffetas and damask, and indulge in more complex patterns. Long gowns trailed on the ground, implying that the wearer was rich enough to afford copious amounts of material. Both sexes wore a voluminous outer garment called a *houppelande*. It fitted on the shoulders, was full and often belted, and draped in folds. The sleeves could be long and wide, sometimes adorned with tinkling bells.

For women, the silhouette was long, with a high waist and small bosom. It was the fashion to walk with the belly slightly protruding and the hips thrust forwards. This helped to carry the weight of the fabric and balance the headgear, as well as to suggest fertility. In this painting, the young couple celebrate their betrothal. The red turban of the young man is decorated with dagged (snipped) material. His fur-lined *houppelande* trails on the ground. Fur and feathers decorate his fiancée's turban, and her dress, derived from the *houppelande*, has a bodice that fits tightly to the hips. The trailing finery and elaborate headgear of the nobility raised moral indignation among the clergy, who reminded the rich that such ostentation was not good for the soul.

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So much pouncing of chisel to make holes, so much dagging of shears, with the superfluity in length of the aforesaid gowns, trailing in the dung and mire, on horse and... foot, as well of man as of woman...

— GEOFFREY CHAUCER, *THE PARSON'S TALE*, 1386–1395

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◀ LES TRES RICHES HEURES DU DUC DE BERRY

Known simply as *The Book of Hours*, this richly decorated prayer book was commissioned by John, Duke of Berry, between 1412 and 1416. The page here represents April, and shows a young couple exchanging engagement rings.

